

Mere Tokenism

MINISTRY OF MINORITY AFFAIRS

Staff: 250

Wages and allowances: **Rs 5.15 crore**

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: **Rs 512.83 crore**

RATIONALE: Overall policy, planning, coordination, evaluation and review of the regulatory and developmental programmes of the minority communities; driving policy initiatives for minorities in consultation with other ministries and state governments.

REALITY CHECK: The fact that the Government of India could do without a ministry for minority affairs for 57 years is perhaps the best argument against the formation, existence and continuation of this ministry. Its creation under the UPA is also testimony to the tokenism being practised by the Congress and its allies.

Sure there is a dire need to ensure delivery of resources to the economically backward groups in the country. This could range from creation of policies that enhance education, enable employment and afford a shot at entrepreneurship. All of these are really in the domain of the respective ministries, from education to health to finance, which are in any case supposed to ensure that the weak get the first charge of the resources. Assuming

that this was not happening, is the Ministry of Minority Affairs empowered to deliver? Indeed there is little evidence of the ministry having even made its presence felt even in the debate following the findings of the Sachar Committee on the educational and employment status of Muslims in India.

The ministry was charged with the implementation of programmes for uplifting the minorities. But the Ministry of External Affairs refused to part with the Haj Committee, and the HRD Ministry refused to part with minority institutions. Eventually, the ministry was asked to oversee the implementation of the 15-point programme—ranging from improvement of educational institutions and scholarships to promoting entrepreneurship and acting on communal harmony. The irony is that all these functions are carried out by eight other ministries. The Ministry of Minority Affairs—which has expanded its staff strength from 159 in 2004 to 250 now—is merely a spectator.

No Precipitation

MINISTRY OF WATER RESOURCES

Staff: 13,076

Wages and allowances: **Rs 218.3 crore**

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: **Rs 871.76 crore**

RATIONALE: To formulate general policy on water resources development, conservation and technical assistance to states; oversee the regulation and development of inter-state rivers.

REALITY CHECK: Water is a national resource. Its management, though, is largely a state subject in the federal structure. Barring inter-state disputes, the responsibility for everything from irrigation to water supply lies with state governments, municipal corporations, local bodies and panchayats.

IT'S A SMALL WORLD

Most modern governments have

UNITED STATES OF AMERICA

The Cabinet normally includes the vice-president and heads of 15 executive departments who are designated as secretaries. These are secretaries of:

- Agriculture
- Commerce
- Defence
- Education
- Energy
- Health and Human Services
- Homeland Security
- Housing and Urban Development
- Interior
- Labour
- State
- Transportation
- Treasury
- Veterans Affairs

■ Under George W. Bush, cabinet rank has also been accorded to Administration, Environmental Protection Agency, Director, Office of Management and Budget, Director, National Drug Control Policy, and the US Trade Representative.

